

Counseling sample tracking scenario

Monday afternoon

Dara and Dan look a bit dazed as they exit their OBGYN's office. They have a lot of questions at the moment, in fact, more than they had coming into the appointment, but both understand the situation they are in. While walking to their car Dan makes the lighthearted joke, "I'm sure glad we don't have to go back to work right now".

Amongst themselves, they have been talking about starting a family for a while and in today's appointment they brought the topic up with Dara's doctor, Dr. Donna Egan. Before that appointment, they knew pregnancy would be considered high-risk as Dara has some long-standing neurological medical issues. Her neurologist has no concerns about a pregnancy or birthing; however, there are some additional measures as a result, compared to a "normal" pregnancy.

Up front, this is where most of Dara and Dan's questions were centered. What they were not prepared for was the topic of genetic testing before a pregnancy.

Both were pretty quiet on the drive home, despite thinking about the same things. Once home, however, they began sharing their thoughts. Dan fully admits his understanding of genetic testing was way off; his first thought when the doctor spoke about it was - "do we get to pick the eye and hair color?". Dara laughs a little in understanding because her first thought was "why do we need to know our ancestry mix before we have a kid? However, it did kick off the conversation, and, after some time, in the end, they understood there are unknowns but agreed that getting genomic testing, relating to family planning, is a good idea. As they understood, it would allow them to have as much information as possible before getting pregnant; which they plan on doing regardless of the results.

Tuesday

It is back to work today for both. On a break, Dara took the opportunity to follow up with Dr. Egan's office, letting them know they would like to proceed with the genetic test for both her and Dan. She was informed another appointment wouldn't need to be scheduled, they just have to stop by the office to get a blood draw. Dan, on the other hand, spend most of his non-working hours googling "what is genetic testing" and even though he did come across a number of

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companies that do this type of DNA testing, he also found a plethora of information that seemed un-scientific, confusing, contradictory, and not as all as helpful as he wanted it to be. By the time he got home Dan was mentally exhausted. Dara, a little more focused, calmed him down and told him they were gonna stop by the clinic tomorrow after work for the blood sample.

Wednesday after work

The two meet via their own cars at the clinic right after work. Dara leads them in and steps to the counter as Dan takes a seat. They are immediately called back, together. The phlebotomist pulls out two Counsyl blood kits, checks a few boxes on the included paperwork, attaches a barcode to the vile and paperwork, and then offers Dan to have a seat. Dara follows, and within less than 15 minutes they are out the door with the Counsyl take-home kit, their viles secured and ready to be picked up at the clinic by FedEx the next day, and both with a mild soreness in the arm.

Dan makes the effort to walk Dara to her car. Gives her a big kiss and tells her “See you at home love”.

Once home Dan relaxes in his chair with the take-home kit. He’s pouring over all the information but still feeling a bit uneasy; not about the test itself, but all the research he’s been doing around DNA testing. He pulls out his phone now that he’s finished reading the kit and scans the enclosed code to (what he believes) set up an account as a part of this testing process.

The code directs him to a personalized welcome page for him and Dara. He’s delighted by the congratulatory message about their decision to start a family. On the site, he enters in contact information and sets up his notification preferences (email over text), reads that the process usually takes 2 weeks for results to be returned but that they will be notified every step of the way.

Friday

An email comes in midmorning notifying Dara and Dan that their samples have been received, the testing process has begun, and that they can follow along and track progress if they choose, through their Counsyl account.

When Dara read the email, she appreciated the update but had no desire to track the progress. Dan on the other hand barely read the email and was already in the account looking at the tracker. There is more information now, and Dan is digesting that just as he did when he set the account up. Now he sees an expected completion date, that their samples are in the second step, processing, and that there are 5 steps total.

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Next Thursday

By now Dan feels like he's well-informed about DNA testing; he talks about it at work, a little too much around the house, and today, like every day prior, he checks the tracker to see if any updates have been made.

Dara, on the other hand, has been pretty quiet. She is nervous about what the results will show, anxious that it is taking so long, (in this moment) hates that she has this neurological issue, and Dan is fueling this anxiety by talking about it, what seems to be, non-stop. When all she wants is for him to STOP.

Dan knows she is stressed. Maybe he is too, but they deal with it much differently. He is hoping that all this information will help put her at ease, but so far it hasn't; although he keeps trying. He tells her, again, that this is the longest stage of the process... Dara doesn't hear him, she's been tuning this stuff out for days now.

"WOULD YOU PLEASE STOP!"

Dan freezes.

He tries to provide some comfort, but her body language tells him it is not going over well. Some minutes pass, Dan thinks it was an hour, but it was far less, and they start talking a little calmer now. Dara wants to call Dr. Egan and find out what is taking so long, as well as ask her a slew of other erratic questions bouncing around her head. She's done talking about this with Dan, or better said, listening to Dan, and wants her questions answered by the doctor.

For a moment Dan thinks this is a good idea as well, but pauses for a moment. He grabs the laptop and asks Dara to have a seat on the sofa. She does, without any words, just tension in her legs as she walks over to sit. Dan joins her and has their account page open. He proposed, rather than calling the doctor, how about we contact a genetic counselor through Counsyl?

Dara stares for a moment, takes the computer, and clicks on the button to speak with a counselor now. Aside from introducing himself when prompted, Dan says nothing. For the whole conversation, Dara's bin of questions is getting answered. Dan's shocked, he wasn't thinking about most of this.

The conversation lasts for about 40 minutes. Dara feels at ease, and no longer needs to call Dr. Egan. Just before saying thank you and their goodbyes, the counselor reminds them that they have a dedicated genetic counselor which whom they can schedule time as often as they'd like. This call was on demand, but the notes will be written up to ensure this conversation isn't lost. Dara jumps in and asks "How do I know who my counselor is?"

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“Oh, that can be found in the introduction email that was sent when your samples first arrived, but on your account page, if it click the schedule button (not the now button) you’ll be able to see that counselor’s information and availability”.

Thank yous all around, plus a sturdy wave from Dan, and the computer is closed.

Dara takes a deep breath and lets out a chuckle. She says to Dan, “I didn’t even notice we had a counselor assigned to us. I read the email, but it didn’t stick”. Dan countered with an apology really not reading the email and took to action rather than even a moment to reflect.

Monday

The results are ready.